Over onto itself

At first glance the elegant wooden jewelry by American artist steven KP appears to be just that. Yet these lyrical objects must also be read as metaphors for the queer lived experience. Although not readily apparent upon an initial viewing, their graceful, meticulously carved gestures denote a need among queer people to pass as conventional to be safe, just as the jewelry actually passes between spaces via their flowing lines which, nonetheless, remain stationary—thus symbolizing stable queer relationships and dependencies—each self-reliant as it loops around and folds over, onto itself.

The nature of wood and its inherent “wounds,” along with the process of removal and refinement, can be interpreted as symbolic of the ongoing trauma of living in a society that disavows one’s authentic self if one is atypical. KP’s latest series, aptly named over, onto itself, is rooted in that marginalization, although the works represent hope by the tender process used in their creation, soft lines, ability to override gravity’s universal truth by bending to it so as to pass beyond, and obligatory perpetual care, as wood must be oiled annually to maintain a healthy life.

In addition to elongated and circular brooches and pendants, along with those that hang from tabs or cords, KP has made necklaces which, more than any other jewelry format, imply a reciprocal relationship with the wearer, as necklaces rely on the body for resolution. Assembled from a series of solid wooden rectangles, upon which undulating elements, which have been carved from them, appear to pull away, they may be seen as representing outcasts straining to belong to a society that has habitually rejected them. Strong and empowering, yet lightweight, each jewelry object comes with a dedicated hand-carved wooden box, or shelf, to contain or support it when not being worn.

Toni Greenbaum

Toni Greenbaum is an art historian specializing in 20th- and 21st-century jewelry and metalwork; author of *Messengers of Modernism: American Studio Jewelry 1940-1960* and book chapters and essays for arts publications. She lectures internationally and teaches Theory and Criticism of Contemporary Jewelry at Pratt Institute in Brooklyn, New York.